



THE SBI FOUNDATION VILLAGE DEVELOPMENT MODEL: Finding the missing link in grassroots development efforts

The 'Give a person a fish...' saying might be the most time-worn allegory, but the impact sector is waking up to its criticality after tinkering with development models that either proved ineffective or lost momentum. India lives in its villages, and the worthiest pursuits in the development sector are those that make this mammoth section of the population self-reliant or 'atmanirbhar', reducing dependence on philanthropic interventions or government welfare efforts over time. The holy grail - and largely missing link in public and private welfare efforts - for achieving this outcome is 'community participation.'



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What is the Participatory Approach in Program Development?

The nodes of the rural system have their roles cut out for them for propelling rural society and economy forward; India's 3-tier Panchayati Raj System turns districts into independent, self-governed units, with a battery of officials and elected representatives at the district, block and ward, panchayat and village levels. Philanthropists and large Corporates' CSR funds have resources to allocate. Civil Society Organisations or CSOs with grassroots networks procure funds from government and private institutions to design and implement interventions, in addition to the government's welfare efforts. Development projects enabling the convergence of these nodes - Government Departments, Gram Panchayats, Schools, Anganwadis,

Health Centres, etc., for achieving quality and scale, is an increasingly mainstream conversation. But the most important cog in this machine, often what the efficacy of the entire operation hinges on, is the community that the intervention is targeted towards.

The theme of the 74th Republic Day, 'Jan-Bhagidari (participation of people)', also invokes this model. 'Jan Bhagidari' refers to the central role of the collective in the policy-making process, from formulation to implementation. When we speak of systemic reform, we put the responsibility squarely on the institutions functioning at the grassroots level - but the onus lies on the communities too, to be receptive, show initiative and participate. Find the nearest exasperated impact sector professional, and they will tell you that "mobilising the community" is the

bane of their existence. Building community participation into the structure of the intervention can make or break one's projects. Communities however, can be risk averse on several, often valid, grounds - knowing the intervention doesn't fit their socio-economic context, hesitance to contribute labour in already labour-strewn lives for projects without evidence of success, etc.

State Bank of India has been taking pioneering steps to help communities work through these apprehensions through its CSR arm SBI Foundation. Established in 2015, the Foundation anchors several interventions at a nation-wide scale to alleviate India's key developmental challenges. Our flagship program 'SBI Gram Seva' has an overt participatory component, making it a model village development program. Under this integrated rural devel-